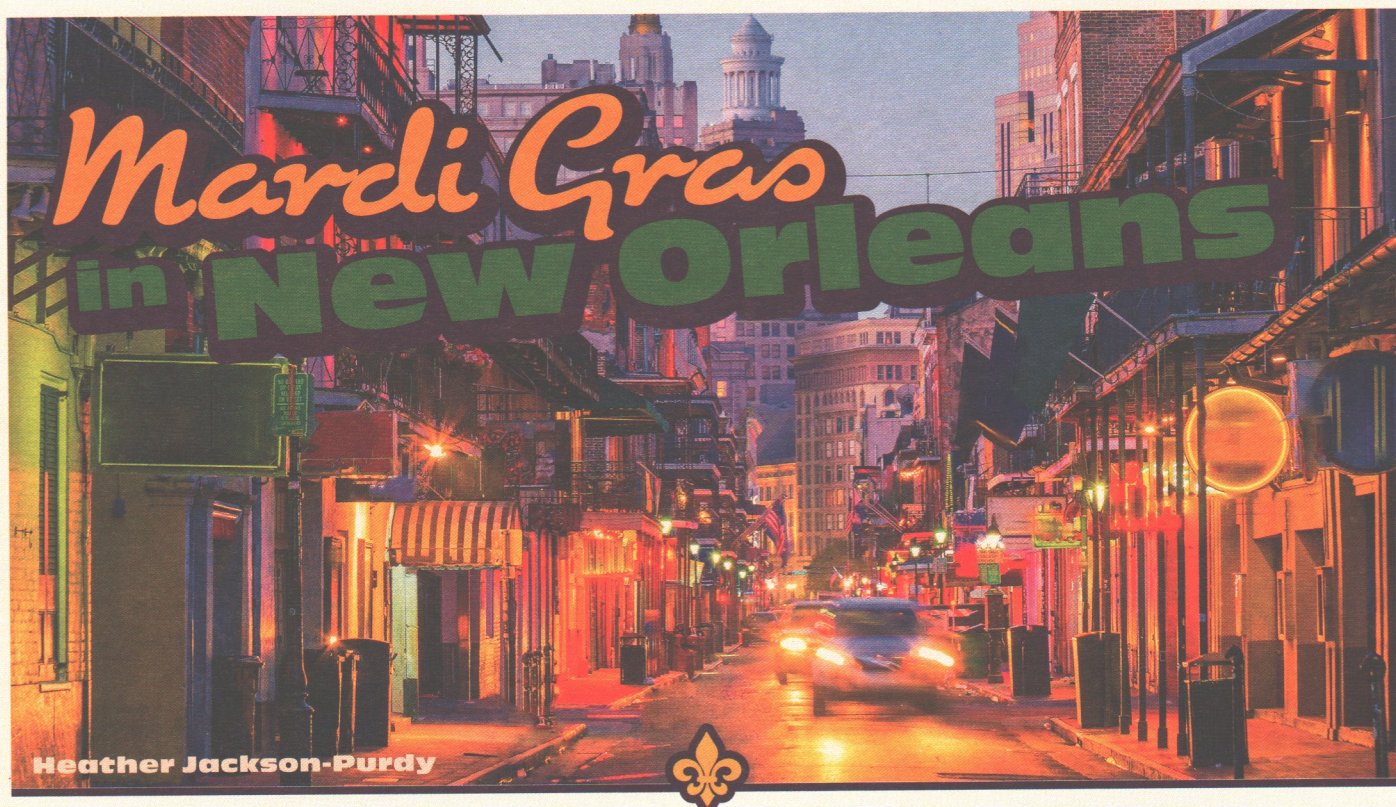




In New Orleans, Mardi Gras is far more than a day of celebration! It's also the grand finale of a weeks-long season known as Carnival. Based on the Christian calendar, Carnival lasts from the celebration of Epiphany on Jan. 6 until Ash Wednesday – when a period of repentance called Lent begins. To the people of the Big Easy, as well as those who visit, Carnival is a time to let loose and live life to the fullest before this solemn season commences.

A brief history of Mardi Gras

Although it is now a beloved Louisiana tradition, the celebration of the Carnival season has its roots far beyond the Gulf Coast. With its origins in medieval Europe, Mardi Gras is said to have started in Rome, then eventually made its way across Europe. From there, the holiday crossed the ocean to the cities of the New World, including New Orleans.

It was during the mid-1800s that groups of masked partygoers first assembled to celebrate Carnival in the Crescent City. These revelers paved the way for the current krewe system.

What is a krewe?

Contrary to popular belief, the city is not responsible for planning or funding Carnival parades. Rather, local organizations called *krewe*s organize their individual events. Evolved from secret societies of revelers, modern-day krewe>s are clubs that are responsible for floats, parties and goodwill throughout

Carnival. Membership requirements vary by organization, but they say there's a krewe for everyone — from walking parades for kids to intergalactic celebrations for sci-fi fans.

Each krewe has a captain who is the overall leader of their organization. These captains work tirelessly behind the scenes to make their krewe's events a success, but they are often overshadowed by the krewe's more public figures: the court. Most krewe>s have a court as dictated by their charters, and it can include kings, queens, dukes, maids and any other role the krewe sees fit to include. Sometimes, members of the court aren't even necessarily human! In the case of one of New Orleans' "dog krewe>s," the reigning king — who has served an impressive tenure of five years running — is a Great Dane named Trésor.

Every season, each krewe will center its celebrations around a new theme, which will dictate the design of its events and some of its floats. Certain krewe>s have been around for decades, while other, newer outfits are bringing a modern twist to Carnival.



Trésor, the reigning king of That Doggone Krewe of Sir Barksalot. Photo courtesy of Nonah Turner, krewe captain and founder.

Parades and Balls

For visitors, the most recognizable tradition is the slew of parades put on by NOLA's Carnival krewes. Beginning in the mid-1800s, these events evolved over time from modest processions into the grand celebrations we know today. In 1870, the use of "throws," often souvenir beads or medallions, was introduced, and by 1872, Rex, the King of Carnival who officially declares the start of Mardi Gras, made his debut.

Today, everyone in New Orleans has their favorite parade, be it that of an old-line krewe like the Krewe of Hermes, or an edgier, more artistic group like the Krewe of Muses. Each krewe's parade times and routes tend to be standardized from season to season, although surprises can happen, particularly in recent years.

One of the more exciting changes of the past decade has been the addition of several late night parades, some of which are the first "rolling" celebrations to be allowed within the French Quarter. While they might cause a traffic nightmare for the

locals, these parades are an artistic marvel and have been instituted by some of the newer organizations, including the Mystic Krewe of Marie Laveau and Tous les Bouffons.

Although these night owl-friendly additions might draw younger crowds to New Orleans, for the most part, Carnival is still a locally based, family-friendly event. When an organization's bad behavior does occur — such as the Krewe of the Pirate Brothers Jean and Pierre's ungentlemanly antics along Esplanade Avenue last season — the City of New Orleans is quick to act.

In addition to the parades, many organizations host an annual ball. This glittering event can take place on the evening of the parade, or on another evening at the krewe's discretion, and is often based around the krewe's theme for that year. Each organization's ball is a dazzling, unforgettable celebration, and obtaining a place in one of these events is the closest you can get to the heart of Carnival — besides, of course, joining a krewe. In fact, many krewes recruit future members at their balls, so you never know what might result from attending!

If, for some reason, you're unable to snag an invitation for an individual krewe's fête, you might be able to attend the Three Kings Ball instead. Founded by artist Celestine Broussard to raise money for NOLA KidsArt, the event takes place every year on Epiphany, the first day of the Carnival season, and its silent auction is the stuff of legend. While this event is certainly more restrained than the average krewe ball, you can still catch a piece of Mardi Gras magic — and perhaps find your way into a krewe of your own.

Whether your visit is as short as a weekend or as long as a season, the Carnival revelry in New Orleans offers something for everyone. With the celebration's rich history and varied offerings, it won't be long before you find yourself swept off your feet by the magic of Mardi Gras. All you need to do is sit back, relax and, as the locals say, *laissez les bons temps rouler!*

Fortier's Fried Chicken

Good ol' pickins

We grew up here, and so did our parents and grandparents, too. It's in our blood. The flavors, preparation, and down-home love of real Louisiana have always been front and center at Fortier's restaurants... where we serve nothing but good ol' pickins!